

TOPIC 2: RIGHTS AND DUTIES OF CITIZENS

1. Fundamental Human Rights

Fundamental human rights are the basic rights and freedoms that every person is entitled to simply because they are human beings. In Nigeria, these rights are protected by the 1999 Constitution (as amended) in Chapter IV.

Some important fundamental rights include:

- **Right to Life** – every person has the right to live and not to be killed unlawfully.
- **Right to Dignity of the Human Person** – freedom from torture, inhuman or degrading treatment.
- **Right to Personal Liberty** – freedom from unlawful arrest or detention.
- **Right to Fair Hearing** – right to a fair trial in a court of law.
- **Right to Privacy** – privacy of home, correspondence and personal life.
- **Right to Freedom of Thought, Conscience and Religion.**
- **Right to Freedom of Expression** – freedom to hold and express opinions.
- **Right to Peaceful Assembly and Association.**
- **Right to Freedom of Movement** within Nigeria.
- **Right to Freedom from Discrimination** on grounds of sex, religion, ethnic group, etc.
- **Right to Own Property.**

2. Duties and Obligations of Citizens

Duties (or obligations) are the responsibilities that citizens must perform in return for the rights and protection they enjoy from the state.

Major duties of Nigerian citizens include:

- **Loyalty to the Nation** – to be loyal and faithful to Nigeria.
- **Obedience to the Law** – to obey the Constitution and all other laws.
- **Payment of Taxes** – to pay taxes, rates and levies honestly.
- **Defence of the Country** – to defend Nigeria when called upon (e.g. military service).
- **Respect for National Symbols** – the flag, anthem, currency and coat of arms.
- **Promotion of National Unity** – to live in peace and promote harmony.
- **Protection of Public Property** – not to destroy or vandalise government property.
- **Participation in the Political Process** – to vote and be voted for when eligible.
- **Respect for the Rights of Others.**
- **Helping Law Enforcement** – to assist the police and report crimes.

3. Relationship between Rights and Duties

Rights and duties are two sides of the same coin. They are interrelated and interdependent:

- Rights cannot exist without duties. If everyone only claims rights without performing duties, society will collapse.
- Performing duties helps to protect and guarantee the rights of others.
- A citizen who enjoys the right to education has the duty to study hard and respect teachers.
- The right to freedom of expression comes with the duty not to spread false information or hate speech.
- Paying taxes (a duty) enables the government to provide roads, schools and hospitals (which citizens enjoy as rights).

4. Consequences of Neglecting Civic Duties

When citizens fail to perform their duties, the following problems arise:

- Breakdown of law and order.
- Poor development – lack of funds for infrastructure due to tax evasion.
- Increase in crime and insecurity.
- Weak and corrupt government.
- Social conflicts and disunity.
- Loss of rights – government may restrict rights when citizens are irresponsible.
- National underdevelopment and poverty.

5. Summary

Every citizen has fundamental rights protected by the Constitution and corresponding duties to the nation. Rights and duties are inseparable. Neglecting civic duties leads to disorder, underdevelopment and insecurity. Responsible citizens balance the enjoyment of rights with the faithful performance of duties.

End of Topic 2 – Rights and Duties of Citizens